

– similar to the dock on OS X or the taskbar on Windows. These shortcuts are completely customizable. The topmost shortcut on the Unity Launcher, as it's called, is for the Ubuntu Dash, which is the focal center of the desktop. From here, you can search for files, applications, documents, music and even items on the web. If you decide to install some additional software (such as the codecs for playing MP3 and DVD files, which aren't included due to licensing constraints), you can do so from the Ubuntu Software Center – a sort of AppStore for Ubuntu apps. Only users with root access can install or remove applications from Ubuntu. Every time you make a change, you'll be asked for your password. It might seem slightly annoying at first, but it's one of the things that makes Linux systems so very secure.

II. Choices, Choices, Choices

The core idea behind Linux is that of Open Source Software – that which can be freely modified and redistributed by anyone. As a result, ambitious developers who aren't satisfied with what's currently on offer, either fork an existing project or create a new one from scratch. One consequence of this is that Linux users are flooded with many choices – whether it's distributions, graphical interfaces or applications. All of it can be overwhelming to the new user, so we dealt with the first part (Linux distributions) in the previous section on installation. Graphical interfaces is what this part is all about. (We'll deal with applications in the next part, where we give you a complete lowdown on the best Linux alternatives to Windows applications)

The basic building block of graphical interfaces in Linux (and other OSes too) is the Window Manager. As the name suggests, this is the program that is tasked with actually 'drawing' the application windows along with the associated operations like resizing, moving, maximizing etc. The Window Manager works closely with the X.Org display server, an open source implementation of the X Windowing System. Window Managers can be used standalone, or they can be bundled together along with UI chrome like toolbars, window decorations, taskbar/docks, icons, wallpapers etc. into one cohesive unit called a Desktop Environment. Most Desktop Environments will also include a selection of applications and some utilities for customizing the behaviour or appearance of the system. As a result, Desktop Environments are usually more full-fledged and are easier for new users to latch onto, while Window Managers, being focused on slightly more advanced users, give the user unrivaled customizability and a tiny system footprint.